is differentiated into two compartments, the outer compartment or **outer cortex,** is densely packed with immature T cells called thymocytes, whereas the inner compartment or medulla is sparsely populated with mature thymocytes. One of its main secretions is the hormone **thymosin**. It stimulates the T cell to become mature and **immunocompetent**. By the early teens, the thymus begins to atrophy and is replaced by adipose tissue **(Fig. 7.12).** Thus thymus is **most active** during the **neonatal and pre-adolescent periods**.

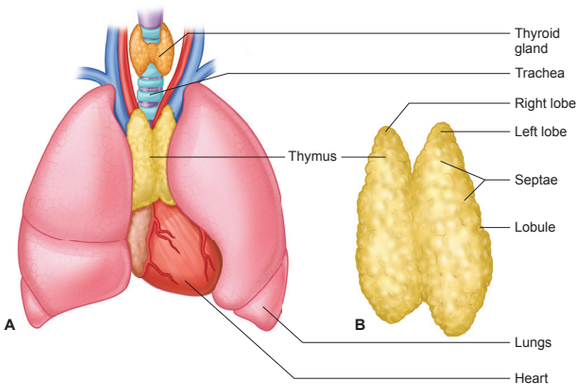


Fig. 7.12 Primary lymphoid organ - Thymus A) Location B) Structure

Bone marrow

Bone marrow is a lymphoid tissue found within the spongy portion of the bone. Bone marrow contains stem cells known as haematopoietic cells. These cells have the potential to multiply through cell division and either remain as stem cells or differentiate and mature into different kinds of blood cells.

Secondary or peripheral lymphoid organs

In secondary or peripheral lymphoid organs, antigen is localized so that it can be effectively exposed to mature lymphocytes. The best examples are lymph nodes, appendix, Peyer's patches of gastrointestinal tract, tonsils, adenoids, spleen, **MALT** (Mucosal-Associated Lymphoid Tissue), **GALT** (Gut-Associated Lymphoid Tissue), **BALT** (Bronchial/Tracheal-Associated Lymphoid Tissue).

Peyer's patches are oval-shaped areas of thickened tissue that are embedded in the mucus-secreting lining of the small intestine of humans and other vertebrate animals. Peyer's patches contain a variety of immune cells, including macrophages, dendritic cells, T cells, and B cells.

The **tonsils** (palatine tonsils) are a pair of soft tissue masses located at the back of the throat (pharynx). The tonsils are part of the lymphatic system, which help to fight infections. They stop invading germs including bacteria and viruses.

Spleen is a secondary lymphoid organ located in the upper part of the abdominal cavity close to the diaphragm. Spleen contains B and T cells. It brings humoral and cell mediated immunity.



The **adenoids** are glands located in the roof of the mouth, behind the soft palate where the nose connects to the throat. The adenoids produce antibodies that help to fight infections. Typically, the adenoids shrink during adolescence and may disappear by adulthood.

Lymph node

Lymph node is a small bean-shaped structure and is part of the body's immune system. It is the **first one to encounter** the antigen that enters the tissue spaces. Lymph nodes filter and trap substances that travel through the lymphatic fluid. They are packed tightly with white blood cells, namely lymphocytes and macrophages. There are hundreds of lymph nodes found throughout the body. They are connected

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